

The architect rebuilding the image of architecture

As the nation enters its third century, the architectural profession is in the midst of a manic redefinition brought on, largely, by the current depression in demand for its services.

It's hard to get figures, but a year or so ago the word from New York was that more than half the architects in that city were not working as architects.

Those studying the problem give three main reasons:

1. Too many architects in too few places. Like lemmings, architects flock to cities that have architectural charm, which is another way of saying cities that are already built and don't need architects. Boston is the classic example. But today this is no longer sufficient explanation—even the Sun Belt offers fewer opportunities.

2. Too narrow a definition of what an architect is. Architecture used to be a gentleman's profession. You hung out your shingle and waited for clients. You came into the picture only after your client had already decided he needed a building, found a site, financing, developed a program. You had the talent, he took the risks.

Thus it's been unethical for members of the American Institute of Architects to solicit work, to advertise, to invest money in, or act as building contractors on their own projects. Architects designed, period.

This year the AIA convention in San Diego in the spring will be voting on a revolutionary proposal to abandon all these rules except the ban on advertising, and even that may soon fall to a Federal government action claiming restraint of trade.

The new AIA president, John McGinty, would like to broaden the concept of an architect even further by admitting draftsmen, engineers and others, who design the environment but aren't registered architects, into the once-clubby AIA.

In an "Engineering News-Record" interview he says: "The alternative is to limit our membership to those engaged in traditional practice, which is decreasing in quantity and importance relative to the whole of the built environment."

In truth, architects design only about a sixth of what gets built in this country, and the other five-sixths shows it. Few get an architect when they plan the latest Acton condo complex.

3. Too remote an esthetic. It's notorious by now that in this century the more avant-garde architects moved too far from what ordinary people said they liked. Not only was this suicide, it was also hypocrisy. Architects played at being "Scientific" by calling kitchens "food preparation centers" and succeeded only in blinding themselves to the fact that a kitchen is also the dog's home and a family social area, and won't work if it's planned as tightly as a laboratory, and won't be liked if it looks like one.

Yet, while being theatrically scientific in this way, leading architects were also playing the role of artists by

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incorporating the stylistic trends of painters and sculptors—especially Cubist and minimalist ideas—into buildings the architects went on blandly describing as "honest," which meant free from applied stylistic decoration. They got into an esthetic corner they are only now getting out of. They've learned that architecture isn't a branch of physics or sculpture, but it's a lesson that came slow.

The metaphor to describe how architects see themselves is changing from Lord Byron flouting the Philistines (as with, Le Corbusier or Frank Lloyd Wright) to an idea of a service profession. The architecture of heroic, visionary proposals — lay waste, build new — is giving over to a notion of architecture as the medical care of the built environment — the architecture of patching, replacing, renewing, cleaning, grafting, consulting, and only rarely using radical surgery.

Few people ask a doctor if his operation was "creative" or "utopian." They only care if it works. Architects should be so modest.

It is likely that this year will be a watershed in the history of the profession. Good design is desperately needed in our society in quantities that would more than employ all the architects alive. It's a question of putting the disease and the healer together.